Winged Reason

(Poems)

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K V Dominic



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Dedicated to

My Beloved Father,

(Late) **Varghese Kannappilly**

Foreword

Human mind is conditioned by experiences of and experiments with life. It is from mind that everything of imaginations, emotions, compassions, thoughts and revelations sprout. Poetry is the output of all those which emanate from the mind. I know Prof. K. V. Dominic personally, and the poems included in this current collection, entitled *Winged Reason*, are quite compatible with his mindset and mindscape.

Prof. K. V. Dominic, a faculty member of the Post-Graduate Department of English, Newman College, Thodupuzha, Kerala, India, and editor of the reputed biannual journal, *Indian Journal of Postcolonial Literatures*, is a sensitive and compassionate man whose sensitiveness and compassion are abundantly manifested in his poems. The following lines:

> I wish I had the claws of a vulture
> to fetch the skeletons from Iraq
> and build a bone-palace
> to imprison Bush in it.
>
> ("A Blissful Voyage")

demonstrate how much he is pained by the Iraq war massacre. He is again pained to find plenty and poverty still staying together in our society:

> A wedding lavished feast was served in the town hall,
> rich were relished by the pompous guests delicacies
> heaped on the plates.
> I could see two ragged girls outside
> struggling with the dogs in the garbage bin.
>
> ("A Nightmare")

Dominic's perception of beauty is discernible in the line, "Eternal Beauty is in Achievements Eternal" ("Beauty").

Dominic describes the pathos of the modern cyber age civilisation, where children are sojourning to the opulent West, leaving old parents who are waiting for a phone call:

looking at the far West,
longing for her children's calls,
she remains lonely
How lucky were her parents!
Lived happy, died happy;
always with their children.

("Gayatri's Solitude")

This is a scenario of the current loveless society.

Dominic expresses anguish against man's unequal treatment towards fellowmen which plants and animals never do:

Plants and animals never divide
the earth among themselves;
What right has the mortal man
to divide and own this immortal planet?

("Haves and Have-nots")

Dominic's feeling for a sightless girl student in the classroom is affectionate and compassionate:

She is the light of the class,
light of the family,
light of the village,
but alas the light never sees itself.

("Helen and her World")

Dominic is a sympathetic and compassionate poet who is pained at humans' wanton felling of trees and destroying of nature's natural body ("I am Just a Mango Tree").

The poet's haiku on Nature's bounties are splendid:

The Sun Kisses

The eye opens
Lotus blooms
("Nature's Bounties")

He is philosophic in several poems:

The sun of knowledge
can never be eclipsed
by the moon of ignorance.
("Solar Eclipse")

Dominic has attempted to show how evils and sins are done by man in the name of God:

God is dethroned
in the name of God.
And human gods are crowned
in the name of God.
("In the Name of God")

Dominic's compassion, sympathy, philosophy are abundantly present in thirty nine poems in this collection.

In fine I should like to say:

He sang songs of his soul
which are compatible with
those of humanity whole.

Pronab Kumar Majumdar
(Former Secretary to the Govt. of W. Bengal)
Poet, Playwright, Short Story Writer & Translator
Editor: Bridge-in-Making (International Literary Journal)

Preface

Winged Reason is my maiden book of free verse consisting of thirty nine poems. It is the fruit of my five years of poetic voyage. Why the poetic muse eluded me till I was forty-eight was a question which my wife asked me recently and I was not able to give a satisfactory reply. The reason might be that my life had been smooth and comfortable without much itching of the mind or arrows stuck into it. As Jayanta Mahapatra wrote, poetry comes out of a "bad heart"—a heart that makes one turn secretly into a leader or a loser, pushing one to choose values, attitudes and do the not-so-obvious things ("Piercing the Rocks: Silence to Poetry"). I do believe that I matured very late, at the age of forty-eight, to be able to choose values and impart them to my students as well as to readers of my poems. Let me quote again Jayanta Mahapatra, who has been the greatest influence on my poetic musing:

> Poetry has always been responsible to life. By this, one means that a poet is first of all responsible to his or her own conscience; otherwise he or she cannot be called a poet. And maybe the other factors necessary to the makings of a good poet, will only come later. These may ordinarily imply the craft, or the language the poet will use with skill in his poems. But somehow, these appear as frills in a poem that is already full with feeling, because the poem would have already done what it was meant to do; in other words, touch another human being, before one came to notice the other qualities of the poem. ("Piercing the Rocks: Silence to Poetry")

Let me make a criticism of my poems, as Seamus Heaney, the Nobel Laureate, has always been doing to his poems. As a poet, I am responsible to my own conscience and I want to convey an emotion or a message often through social criticism. I have a commitment to my students as a professor; to the reader, scholars and writers as an editor; and to all human and non-human beings as a poet. Hence I give priority to the content of a poem than to its style. That is why my poems lack much imagery and other figures of speech. I am of the opinion that poetry should be digestible as short stories and novels are appealing to the laymen. I adopt a conversational style in poetry, which again attracts the ordinary readers. Here I am influenced much by the Victorian, poet, Robert Browning.

So the reason why my mind disallowed "robins" (a captivating image often used by my friend and great Indo-Canadian poet, Stephen Gill), to enter and nest, is the security and comfort I enjoyed throughout my life. Stephen Gill has thus written in the preface to his masterpiece *The Flame*, "Discriminations and religious riots produced fears. They demolished whatever walls of security we had. These factors led me to the caves of isolation, thinking, browsing, and imagining that prepared a good recipe to be a poet" (14). Compared to Stephen Gill's younger days in New Delhi, I have been living in this part of my country where there has been no communal riot or terrorist attack, and I have been positioned in the midst of plenty. Kerala, my State, is known outside as God's own land. There is equable climate; greenery and natural beauty distinguish it from other States and tourists flood in from all parts of the world here. Literacy is cent per cent here and a majority of the teenagers receive education in schools and colleges. People have a tendency to imitate the ways of the West, but unlike the Western people, the major concern of the people is religion.

I have respect for Hinduism and Buddhism as they believe in Ahimsa. I feel remorse for having been a non-vegetarian, eating meat and fish for fifty years. It is not an easy thing to change my staple when everyone around me dines with meat and fish. The death of my favourite twin cats haunts me everyday and pricks my heart to bleed to new pastures of social criticism.

The world now shudders most because of terrorist attacks. Teenagers and youth are attracted to terrorism, mesmerised by the

noble idea of self-sacrifices done to God. The anti-social leaders of terrorism exploit their religions to bring down the society to chaos, angst and panic. They loot the people, kidnap innocent persons and amass billions through bargains. The irony is that they do it in the name of God. When we go through the pages of world history, we find that most of the homicides and genocides were done in the name of God.

Another thorn that pierces my heart is the corruption indulged in by politicians and government officials. Poor people are strangled through taxes and their governments do nothing for their welfare. The government is always with the rich, caring for their comfort and luxury. The rich can evade taxes; exploit the weaker sections; torture and kill anyone they like; they get the protection of police; can escape legal punishments. Why? Because they have money. In fact, my country as well as the world as such is ruled by a few multimillionaires who constitute not even one per cent of the world population. It is a shocking truth that a thousand million people live in this world without a square meal a day when raw and cooked food in thousands of tons is wasted every day. How can we justify this luxury? One can become rich only at the exploitation of the poor. It is the duty of the rich as well as the developed countries to alleviate the miseries of the poor.

The above-mentioned are the arrows and thorns that pierce my heart every day and the gushing blood runs through my pen to paper. Now, let me explain the immediate provocation which fired my imagination. One of my colleagues, Prof. George Joson, of the Department of Mathematics drowned in a river as he was driving back to his house at 11 pm on 14 May 2004. It was raining cats and dogs throughout the night, and the body was found in the early morning frozen in the driver's seat of his car. Had there not been a flood in the river that night, he would not have died. He was my intimate friend, living with his unemployed wife and three little daughters—resembling three angels—just two hundred metres away from my house. Thus my "bad heart", heavy and brimming with grief, released the tension on paper after two days. The poetic muse—let me call it cuckoo, the bird which I like most—started to sing in my mind. Thank God, He sent the cuckoo to sit on the branch of my mind before it dried by old age. My first poem, "In Memoriam George Joson" was

followed by "Long Live E. K. Nayanar." E. K. Nayanar, the Communist Chief Minister of Kerala, died on 15 May 2004, the day when Joson's body was buried. Nayanar was the most lovable CM, Kerala had ever borne. He was highly humourous, simple and as innocent as a lamb. Being a Socialist I have great love and respect for him. These two poems were published one after another in *Kerala Private College Teacher*, a journal of All Kerala Private College Teachers' Association, and won acclaim from professors and lecturers in Kerala.

The popularity gained through the poems goaded me to write more and more, and I tried my pen on various social issues. The major theme of my poetry is the eternal relationship between Man, Nature and God. Though a baptised Christian, I am primarily an Indian, and it is my duty as a teacher and poet to instil Indian values to my students and countrymen, and also propagate these noble values to the rest of the world. I believe in the concept of *jeevatma* and *paramatma* (individual soul and universal soul) and that all living beings are part of *Paramatma* or God. Again I believe in the Indian concept of *Aham Brahmasmi* (I am the God). Advaita seems to me more reasonable and acceptable than Dvaita. Thus I find the eternal affinity between Man, Nature and God. Man is not given liberty to kill other beings nor is he allowed to uproot plants and trees for his luxuries. The Creator has given man permission to use plants just for his survival. That is the law of Nature. No animal kills others except for food. Man needs only plants for his sustenance. His teeth and digestive system suit a vegetarian diet. Adam and Eve lived on plants alone in the Garden of Eden. Animals were the close companions of our first parents. This philosophy of life is portrayed in several of my poems. "A Sheep's Wail," "Haves and Have-nots," "I am Just a Mango Tree," "My Teenage Hobby," "Ammini's Lament," "Ammini's Demise," "Om," "How I Became a Vegetarian," are the poems in this book proclaiming this theme.

Disparities in the society, problems of the poor, the downtrodden, the marginalised and the old are the themes of the poems "A Nightmare," "Anand's Lot," "Beauty," "Tsunami Camps," "Gayatri's Solitude," "Helen and Her World," "International Women's Day," "Lal Salaam to Labour," "Laxmi's Plea," "Rahul's World," "Vrinda," "What a Birth!," "Cry of My Child," and "Old Age."

Politics, terrorism, communalism, corruption and exploitation by political parties and religions find subjects of thought in the poems "A Blissful Voyage," "Indian Democracy," "Solar Eclipse," and "In the Name of God."

Description of Nature is found in the poems "Nature's Bounties," "Harvest Feast," "Cuckoo Singing," "Onam," and "Sleepless Nights."

In the poems "Kaumudi Teacher is No More" and "Michael Jackson, King of Kings," two celebrities in different fields are honoured.

The contrast of city and village lives is the theme of "City Versus Village." The ebb and flow of happiness and sorrow is the theme of the poem "Pleasures and Pains." "Connubial Bliss" depicts the divine plan behind marriage. "Human Brain" is a poem drawing a comparison of the human brain with the animal brain. Many of the poems in this book have been published periodically in national and international journals.

Now let me recollect the poets and philosophers who influenced my poetic musings. The Romantic poets—Blake, Wordsworth, Shelley and Keats—fired my imagination considerably. The Victorians like Browning, Tennyson and Arnold, and American poets Frost and Dickinson exercised their influence on me one way or another. Indian English poets—Ezekiel, Mahapatra and Kamala Das—are my models in the use of diction and syntax. My own friends and contemporary poets—Stephen Gill, D. C. Chambial, P. K. Majumder, Hazara Singh, O. P. Arora, Aju Mukhopadhyay, R. K. Bhushan, Jaydeep Sarangi, Sunil Sharma and several others contributed their share in my present development. Christ, Vivekananda, Marx, Darwin, Sree Narayana, Said, Fanon, Gandhi, Nehru, Mother Teresa, Baba Amte, Salim Ali, Steve Irwin are the holy men, philosophers, theoreticians, humanitarians, ecologists and Nature lovers who shaped my view of life.

I am winding up my preface with an acknowledgement to those who inspired me and helped me in the production of this book. First and foremost, my mind flies to Him with a bouquet of gratitude for allowing me to live all these years with a sound body and mind. I give Him special thanks for sending a cuckoo to my mind and making it sing continuously. Secondly

I remember the inspiration given to me by my wife, Anne, and my children, Rose and Joe. They were also good critics of my poems. I am indebted to Prof. K. J. Francis, Nirmala College, Muvattupuzha, Kerala, who has been an admirer of my poems, and it was he who motivated me to publish this anthology. I am much obliged to my bosom friend, Sudarshan Kcherry, the proprietor of Authorspress, New Delhi, for accepting this book for publication. He is a rare gem among publishers—a scholar, a visionary, a sage, and above all, a proper guide to emerging writers. Finally, I express my immense gratitude to my former student, Mr. K. K. Anas, Research Scholar in France, for the wonderful illustrations and cover design of this book.

K. V. Dominic

1. In Memoriam: George Joson

(Elegy written on a colleague who died in a car accident on 14. 05. 2004)

Why did you leave us so soon, dear Joson?
(We are unable to find any reason.)
It stunned and benumbed us.
How unbearable the grief and pain
For your beloved family and friends
The most painful was the sight
When your youngest kid,
not knowing what has happened,
kissed your face
again and again
and plucked flowers
from your wreath;
tossed them to her sisters weeping and screaming
What a game He plays!
When He comes riding His chariot,
none can say—"wait".
Joson
Now we understand the mystery of your ever being fast—
fast in your words;
fast in your walk;
fast in your action,
and FAST UNTO DEATH!
Life is uncertain
for the mighty and the meek
but the labour
of the potent and the weak
grants it certainty .
Also to those
who are our charge
And deny them the risk of fall—
Great is the loss

to academia too.
Your absence, everywhere is haunting
We find it hard
to console and reconcile
with the inevitable!
We are all
bound by His will
to be here
or to be away.
As the great poet sang:
We are all puppets in His hands,
dancing to the tunes He plays.
The best is to resign
to what He ordains
in time and out of time.



2. Long Live E. K. Nayanar

(Elegy written on E. K. Nayanar, man of the masses, who passed away on 15. 05. 2004)

"Long live E. K. Nayanar!"
This mantra is being chanted
by millions of your beloved people.
We are in a trance
since you bade us "Good bye."
It is impossible to believe
our dearest CM is no more.
A vast surging
sea of humanity
followed wailing and weeping
you on your last journey.
No rain could stop them;
no sleep could retreat them.
Thus mourning with the Nature,
your people swarmed round your body,
bidding "Lal Salaam, Lal Salaam."
You were a true Communist;
a comrade to the core of your being,
a rare species,
compassion and love
an epitome of Socialism.
Yet did give due respect and valued
those even who differed with you.

Your rhetoric left a lasting spell;
Your utterances dance
on the tongues and lips of your sheep.
Deep sounding like a bassoon,
it stirred and the public cheered.
Was it mere rhetoric
that enchanted your audience?
Nay, the words came from your heart;
you meant what you spoke.
People believed
what you said.
Such was your charisma;
It reminds us of the rare species
of rhetoricians and statesmen.
You were truly a patriot;
had no foes, only friends.
Your heart bled at the sight of
the tears of the poor,
the miseries of the wretched,
the sufferings of the downtrodden,
pricked your heart often.
You championed the cause of the denied
and the deprived.
your sense of humour was inimitable
very few leaders sparkled in that.
Your absence from amidst us
shows your presence among the stars.
You are our polestar
who saves us from Darkness.
You will continue to steer
the ship of our dear nation
to the land of blessings and bounties.

E. K. Nayanar: Thrice Chief Minister of Kerala, India



3. A Blissful Voyage

Let my mind soar high
on the wings of the Muses
and visit the places
inaccessible.

Had I the wings of a mallard
I could fly to the States,
shake hands with Obama,
and thank my American sisters and brothers.

I wish I had the claws of a vulture
to fetch the skeletons from Iraq
and build a bone-palace
to imprison Bush in it.

If I could fly like an angel,
would plead all prophets
to inspire and instill humanism
in millions' communal minds.
I would meet Gandhi too
who is weeping at his shattered dreams.

I wish I were a bullet
and shoot into the chest of that terrorist
who compels that teenage boy
to explode and kill that innocent mob.



4. A Nightmare

I had a nightmare the overnight;
I was a hawk hovering in the sky.

I could view the cry of an obese boy
whose mother was beating him to eat more.
A cry of a different note was heard from the next door,
where a bony child was crying for a crumb.

A lavish wedding feast was served in the town hall,
rich delicacies heaped on the plates,
were relished by the pompous guests.
I could see two ragged girls outside
struggling with the dogs in the garbage bin.

My wings took me to a public school;
A boy in tears stood on the verandah:
A punishment for not wearing his tie!
In the humid weather of forty degrees
a slavish mimic, a legacy of the West.

What's that long queue I find before that shop?
Like a line of ants before their hole.
God! It's a liquor shop run by the government!
That leper who begged at my door is also in the line!
A similar queue is found on the other side,
where poor women wait for their rations.

Then I found a public water tap
that made the road a black river.

Elsewhere I noticed a waterless tap
laughing at the hopeless wait
of all the pots of the neighbourhood.

See, that mansion a double-storeyed edifice!
Luxury rooms, lawn and swimming pool;
An old man and his wife reside there;
sitting at the phone with sighs and moans,
longed for the calls from their sons abroad.
Not far away were the slums of the city;
three generations lived in each hut;
grandpa, grandma, their sons and their wives,
and their little kids sleep in a room!

Tears streamed down my cheeks.
I could see nothing more;
nor did I wish for it;
The siren sounded as usual
to disturb my nightmare!





5. A Sheep's Wail

Hark, you Man
to my wail,
your enslaved sheep's.

You are possessed with
some special powers
that we do not have.

With your brain
and with your tongue
you conquered us.

Superior you boast,
but inferior you become
to the microbes that kill you.

The fur God gave me,
mercilessly you shear
to make you cosy.

The milk for my lamb
you suck and drain
and grow fat and cruel.

I have seen with my eyes
and heard with my ears
the last cries of my parents.

When they became old
you cut their heads
and ate their flesh.

Man, you are the cruelest,
you are the most ungrateful
of all God's creations.

Yet you find justification
and bring false philosophies
to make you His choicest.

Nothing can be more absurd!
Aren't we His children?
How can He forgive you?

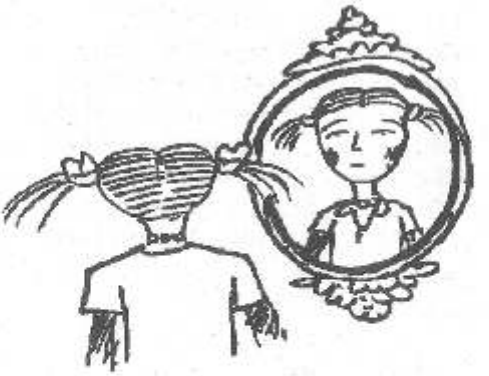
If a heaven is there
we will reach there first
and pray to God to shut you out.



6. Anand's Lot

Anand's eyes were immersed
on the pupils in tempting uniforms;
compared with his shabby ragged dress.
Longed to be one of them again.
How happy were those days!
Mummy gave me kiss and ta-ta;
like butterflies flew to the school
with Rajesh, Praveen and Smitha
chattering, singing, dancing, running.
Alas! Like a vulture came the car then;
picked me in and dashed away.
A bearded-man with a black towel
hushed my helpless wail for help;
brought into a house and shut in a room.
I was fed with cold dry bread
and slept on the floor dead tired.
The car picked me again in the morning
and brought me to this strange city.
They changed my dress
and dressed me in rags.
They threatened to kill me
if I disobeyed their orders.
I have to sleep in their hut,
eat dry bread which I hate;
always wear stinky rags.
They scold me and beat me
for not earning much as they dreamed.

Many months have passed
since I left my mom, dad and Smitha?
Are they still crying at my loss?
Tears streamed down from Anand's cheeks.
"Bloody dog, why are you standing still?"
The bearded-man slapped helpless Anand
"Go to the shops and beg or I'll kill you."
Crying, Anand stretched his hand
went begging
shop after shop.



7. Beauty

Why do you murmur, lass, looking at the mirror?
Ma, why didn't God create me a little more beautiful?
Who told you dear that you are not beautiful?
Bodily beauty is only one among the beauties;
It fades and decays as a flower does.
Who thinks of a flower when it is decayed?
The sun is beautiful but can you enjoy it at noon?
The objects of nature reveal its radiance and beauty.
Eternal beauty is in achievements eternal.
Handsome is he who handsome does.
So it is said.
Look at and think of
Shakespeare, Shaw, Gandhi, Lincoln,
Mother Teresa, Navratilova, Venus, Serena...
Who is more popular, Venus or Aishwarya?
What makes Kalam our dearest President?
Bodily beauty is all subjective and relative;
Some like white, some like black.
No child is ugly to its mother;
Nothing can be ugly, for God created it.
Didn't you feel the snake's beauty
when Lawrence sang in praise of it?
Keats has taught you "beauty is truth"
and "a thing of beauty is a joy forever."
Only spiritual beauty gives eternal joy.
My dear lass, be like the sun,
brightening this dark world with your inner beauty.

8. Connubial Bliss

Proton, electron; positive, negative;
male, female; made for each other.
Pains and pleasures: God's own gifts.
None can reject them.

Divine sex, divine organs;
instincts divine, divine pleasures;
who can abstain them?

The dancing of the plant;
the smiling of the flower;
the chirping of the bird;
and all merry cries of other beings,
herald Life's march here.

Connubial bliss,
heavenly happiness;
merging of two souls;
fulfilment of His plans.



9. Cuckoo Singing

4.30 a.m.
Cuckoos' songs echo:
waking call
for dreaming day.
Sweetest song in Nature;
sweeter than any
man-made music;
Orpheus, Beethovan,
none before it.
Ku, ku, khu, khhu, khhoo;
the note goes
up and up and up and up.
What do the sounds mean?
"Wake up mate,
let's start love" or
"Wake up man and
sweat for your bread"?
Yes, cuckoo lives
singing and loving,
while man exists
sweating and moaning

10. Gayatri's Solitude

Gayatri aged eighty-two,
widowed at thirty-five,
mother of five children:
three sons and two daughters;
all in the States.
Old-age home her haven.
The palatial house
her children built
remains empty at town.
Her room in old-age home
modern with AC.
She will get any food;
all left to her choice.
Her children under illusion:
their mother is cozy.
Poor, miserable mother,
she has no hunger,
she has no sleep.
An old lily flower
pale and faded.
Dawn to dusk,
sitting in an armchair,
looking at the far West,
longing for her children's calls,
she remains lonely.
How lucky were her parents!
Lived happy, died happy;

always with their children:
sons, daughters,
daughters-in-law,
sons-in-law,
a dozen grandchildren,
a house full of mirth.
The depth of maternal love,
and the pangs of separation
no child can gauge.



11. Tsunami Camps

How dreadful the life in Tsunami camps!
People burnt in man-made hells;
gods crazy seeing their sufferings.
Months have passed
since Tsunami tossed them from their houses.
Nothing left but mind and body;
counting days for their salvation.
Lost their dear ones
and fight against destiny.
Camps built of GI sheet
melt inmates trapped in the cells.
A furnace inside, a furnace outside;
mind and body burn with agony.
Each family has a cell in the camp;
they cook and dine and sleep at night;
grown-ups sleep outside, risking nightly rains.
Government gave kits and boxes;
kits don't contain essential things;
hearth produces more smoke than flames.
None hears their cries and complaints:
"Where have gone the crores
collected for our relief?"
Money is hoarded in the government exchequer,
or diverted for some other purposes.
"It's better to kill us than torture like this."
"We don't have sufficient food,
we don't have pure water."

"The filthy atmosphere of the camp
will bring several epidemics."
"Give us boats and nets,
and we will earn our livelihood."
"We don't get any help
either from the Right or from the Left."
Unending wails and unending sobs;
not even gods listen to their cries.



12. Harvest Feast

That photograph in the newspaper
flashes to my mind very often;
Those little pupils from Kozhikode,
avidly feasting rice and payasam;
The harvest banquet of their sweated labour.
Nothing can be tastier than this.

Those nimble, soft feet,
which ran after butterflies;
Those little velvety hands
which caressed plants and flowers,
moved through the rough fields;
ploughed the land; sowed the seed;
plucked the weed; reaped the corn;
carried sheaves on their tender heads;
threshed, husked, cooked.

Their teachers taught them the great lessons:
how education can be vocational;
and the beauty and dignity of labour;
a lesson too to the adult world;
the way to solve the food crisis,
and save the world from poverty.





13. Haves and Have-nots

Haves and Have-nots:
man-made categories;
never in creator's dream.

Abundant Nature
feeds plants and animals.
Greedy selfish man disrupts
Mother Nature's feeding;
uproots millions of trees,
exterminates thousands of animals.
His deadly weapons
pose a great threat
to life itself.

Man is a wonderful work;
Unimaginable his achievements;
Equally heart-rending his destructions.
Achievements prove beneficial
only to Haves a minority.

When millions die of hunger,
thousands compete for delicacies.
Minority always luxuriates
at the cost of
majorities' necessities.

Plants and animals never divide
the earth among themselves;

What right has the mortal man
to divide and own this immortal planet?
What justice is there for the minority
to starve the majority?

How pitiable
that religions give no solace and hope
to the miserable multitudes.

The Have-nots found a haven
in socialism and communism;
no private property;
state-owned wealth;
selfless work for society.
But power corrupted;
leaders turned tyrants;
philosophy failed.
Equality to man utopian.

Capitalism rules the day;
Have-nots numbers swell.
Shattered and smashed
are their dreams
of health and happiness.

14. Helen and Her World

Helen, her restless eyes
pierce my heart very often;
Those lovely eyes of hers,
searching for a ray of light
from the very first day
she came to this world:
a world without
the sun and the moon;
prick my heart and
it bleeds in the class.

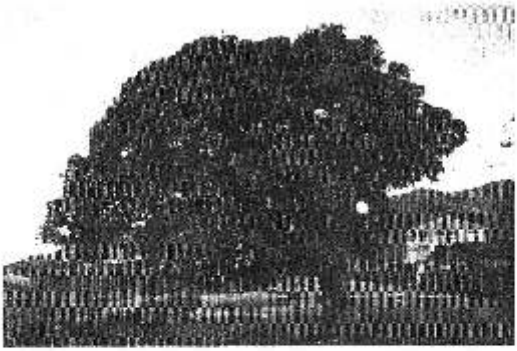
The analogy of the lamp and the pot
I lectured for the Rasa theory;
how the lamp reveals the pot;
sparkles the eyes of others,
while her eyes were still
searching for the lamp and its light.

When she takes down notes,
faster than any typewriter,
ticked, ticked moves her hand
line after line on the Braille;
as I speed to her ticks
others struggle to keep her pace.

She is the brightest in the class;
reads book after book
through her brother's eyes.

Had her scribe known
spellings of all words,
she could have won a rank
in her degree examinations.

She is the light of the class,
light of the family,
light of the village,
but alas the light never sees itself
and, of course,
light shows all
their paths and ways
and can't see 'itself!
What is challenge to the challenged!
Light fighting against darkness,
Eternally! Hopefully! Surely!
Helen is comfortable in life.



15. I am Just a Mango Tree

I am just a Mango Tree;
still an accomplished life;
I've fulfilled my Creator's plan.
Standing like a Himalayan umbrella,
I shelter my student-friends
waiting for the buses.
The Sun can't wither them,
nor can Rain wet them.
Their innocent smiles and laughter;
the lovers, sighs and sobs,
tickle me or make me weep.
When my friend Wind comes,
I welcome him with myriad hands.
My saviour Sun fosters me;
his rays cook food for me;
I grow and bear fruits for others.
When I blossom, flies kiss me.
My branches are the beds for birds;
cuckoos, crows and mynahs come;
when my fruits are ripe, a feast to them.
Their chirps and songs lull me often;
when night comes they sleep on my lap;
I too sleep standing on my feet.
Nightly breeze and dews caress me;
I drop mellow yellow fruit

to my beggar friend who sleeps beneath.
My God, how happy I feel—
The fruit of service!
Hark! What's that boy telling the girl?
"Darling, where shall we wait
when they cut this tree?"
"Dear, why should they cut this tree,
a cool shelter to countless?"
"They plan to build a waiting shed here."
God, what do I hear? Is it true?
'True, my daughter, I am helpless.'
Can't they spare me and
build it somewhere else?
Don't I do them good as to all?
Don't I have feelings and pains
though I endure in silence!?
Haven't I the right to live?
God, why is your Man so selfish and cruel?
Did you create him,
to disturb this earth's balance?
This planet would be a paradise
if You kindly withdraw him.
'My child, I created him
in My own Image
but he's gone-astray;
My agony is endless.
That's the fate
of the Father everywhere.
I shouldn't have created this human species;
But how can a father kill his sons?'



16. International Women's Day

(Composed on 8 March 2009)

International Women's Day;
celebrations all over the world;
meetings held;
programmes chalked out;
promises showered;
funds allotted;
celebrities honoured;
her praises sung hoarse
coarse in her life's course
mockery's rhetoric in these celebrations!
All echoes of years of yore!
Problems remain the same!
Woman is the game!
Birth to death,
an instrument of lust
and hot-selling sex!
Her very birth ill omen:
an unwelcome event.
No guilt in foeticide;
foeticide is matricide;
no life without mother.
Sexism in childhood;
priority to her brother;
her food, his leftover.
Chained in kitchen,
she rarely goes out.
No toys, no plays;

always envies him.
Mum and dad love him;
she gets only reproaches;
beat her very often.
Seldom educated;
hence no employment,
and always dependent.
No choice of her partner;
her individuality
scantily respected.
Born to be dictated;
tyranny everywhere:
slave to her husband,
servant to her in-laws.
Bears the pangs of child-bearing;
endures the rearing of her children.
Dawn to dusk,
blood turns sweat.
Her love and sacrifices
remain unrewarded.
Has not her due in politics:
councils, assemblies, parliaments,
she has little or unheard voice.
Religions also dishonour her:
she has no right
to enter her Father's abode;
no place in clergy.
She is always the Other.
Patriarchy is his product;
he dictates the world;
dictates even God,
and corrupts religion.
He writes scriptures,
makes sexism predestinate.
Venerable is woman,
for she is your mother;
she is your sister;
she is your wife;
she is your guide;
she is your teacher;
she is your nurse;
and above all,
she is your angel.



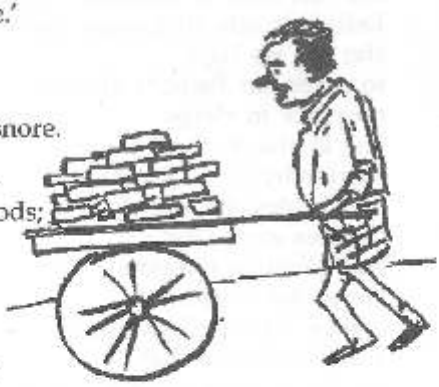
17. Lal Salaam to Labour

Lal Salaam to Labour,
the backbone of the country!

They sow the seed;
reap the corn;
and we eat and sleep.

They spin and weave;
make beautiful clothes;
and we wear and 'shine.'

They build houses
where they never rest,
and there we live and snore.



They sweat in factories;
produce numberless goods;
and we use and enjoy.

They tar the road;
melt in the furnace;
and we ride and drive.

They clean roads and markets;
are shunned by us very often;
and we make them filthier and filthier.

They envy our lives;
nurse bubbles of dreams;

but reality pricks them oft,
and make heaven of tavern.

Lal Salaam to Labour,
for without them we have no life.

Let us not be unjust
when we pay them wages,
for we can't do what they do.

Give them at least their due;
the more we give, the more we get;
Put charity in humanity
a spiritual bliss that never dies.





18. Laxmi's Plea

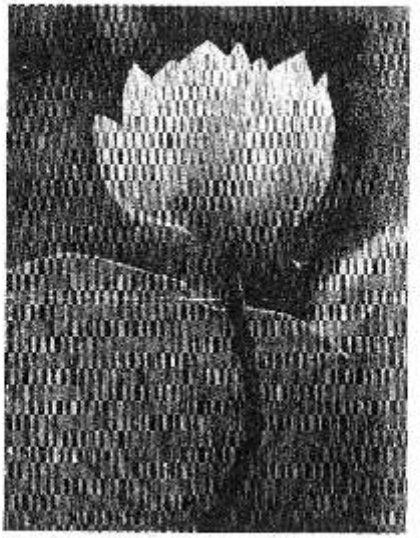
Rekha's wedding today;
my youngest colleague
junior by ten years.
To be or not to be;
present or absent;
a terrible trance!
Auspicious occasion;
jocund jolly hall;
a fish out of water;
I can't slither there.
"Laxmi, when is your wedding?"
"Laxmi, you alone remain."
Can't bear these arrows;
heart full of such arrows;
bleeding day after day.
It's none my fault
single at thirty three.
"Laxmi looks very handsome."
"She is a lamp to any house."
A lamp destined to burn out
under a hot pot.
Plenty of proposals;
appeared with tea
before many young men.
None complained my looks.
"What's the dowry?"
A stumbling block to all proposals.

Father died when I was ten;
mother bed-ridden with cancer;
a thatched house in five cents;
an elder sister married off.
My meagre salary two thousand
hardly meets our food and medicine.
I have pricked my bubble of dreams;
let none dream for me.
Leave me alone;
leave me single.



19. My Teenage Hobby

Angling, my teenage hobby;
evenings at river bank
with Joseph till early night.
Long wait for the catch;
amidst mosquitoes.
Each fish a great thrill;
pulling the fish out of water:
a heavenly experience!
The death struggle
of the innocent fish.
Sadistic pleasure!
Once when I pulled a fish,
flashed a horrible vision:
I am pulled from the sky;
death struggle on the line.
Awestruck and repentant,
I unhooked the fish
and dropped in the water.
No more did I angle;
Reflections on life
became my pastime.



20. Nature's Bounties

(Haiku)

The song of cuckoo
Night's dirge
Day's trumpet

The birth of morn
Temples and mosques chanting hymns
Heaven on earth

The sun kisses
The eye opens
Lotus blooms

Fragrance of the rose
Intoxication to the fly
Dancing round the plant

Jasmine's hand
Caressing touch on my neck
Utter dilemma

Yellow mellow papaya
Longing violent kisses
Feasting crows and mynahs

Lightning and thunder
God's fire works
Frightened man quirks!

Torrential summer rains
A shed of corrugated sheets
God's drum-beats.

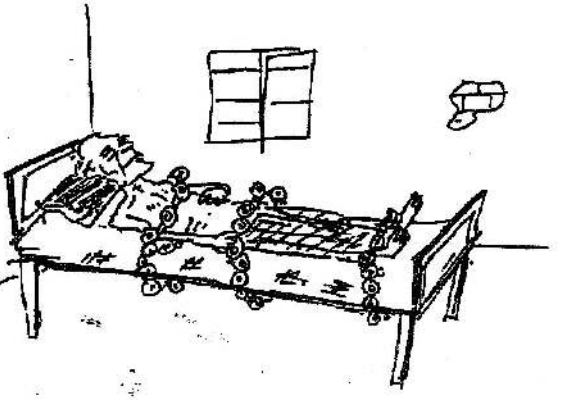
Parched fields
Rain in summer
Honey to the lips

Refreshing downpour
A child in ecstasy
Drenched dancing

Road a river of rainwater
A child on bicycle
Splashing roaring

Snow-capped mountain
Multi-coloured sky
God with the brush





21. Old Age

Human life is a cycle:
born to the earth
with a shrieking cry;
life's first breath.
Bed-ridden first year,
dependent childhood,
independent youth;
gives birth to children;
health wanes;
dependent old age;
body weak;
but mind strong;
bed-ridden at last;
lies back in the earth
with a painful breath.
Childhood is memorable—
carefree and dynamic
no sorrow dares
but happiness glares.
one with Nature;
an angel on earth;
darling to all.
Old age begins to play its colours—
The monarch of yesterday,
feels humbled today.
Imprisoned amidst unripe ripeness;
utterly helpless.

unyielding mind.
The dearest children,
to whom he looked and loved
turn ungrateful.
They hate and curse
And never care.
Ageism is contemptible;
unpardonable too.
Today's torturer
tomorrow's victim;
we live with ironies.



22. Onam

Onam, a national festival;
Keralites celebrate
wherever they are.
Ten-day celebrations
start with Atham:
a harvest festival.
Feasting with new rice
after three months of
continuous monsoon.
Clear sky and bright sunlight;
fragrance and colours
of flowers everywhere.
Early mornings
children run for flowers,
make *pookalams*
at the front yards.
Pookalams with
myriads of flowers
in circular pattern:
a fantastic sight!
People in new dress;
full of gaiety and spirits;
relishing ceremonial food;
delight in Onam songs,
Onam plays and Onam dances.
Spirited competitions:
sports, games and arts;



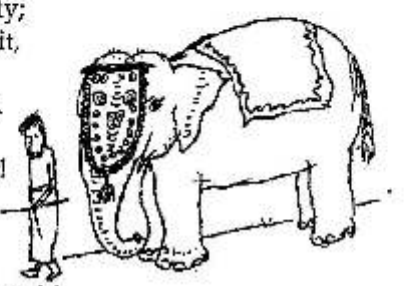




a familiar sight.
Boat races with
dozens of rowers
in bright uniforms,
rowing in perfect rhythm,
singing boat songs,
a pageant of rare beauty in the world.



Onam has a legend:
a remembrance of
the golden rule of Maveli
an icon of the just king.
Equality prevailed in society;
no lies, no crimes, no deceit,
and no cheat;
no poverty, no child death.
All were happy;
Heaven cannot be different!
Envious of Maveli
Vishnu in disguise
stamped on his head
to be thrown in the underworld.
But granted him a boon
to visit his people
once in a year.
Maveli visits on Onam;
Fed up he
he returns in tears





Keralites: People of Kerala, the southern state of India. Known as God's own land it has pleasant, equable climate and high density of population. Full of natural beauties it is dear to foreign tourists.

Pookalams: Flower designs

Vishnu: One of the Trinity in Hindu mythology

23. Rahul's World

"Rahul, get out,"
teacher roared,
class shuddered.
Rahul wept,
stood outside.

Couldn't study
yesterday's portion.
Whose fault?

Drunken father
beat mother,
beat Rahul;
kicked away supper,
none could sleep.

Cruel father,
Cruel teacher,
Cruel world.
Poor Rahul
longs for love.



24. Sleepless Nights

The cuckoo's flute
woke me up at every dawn;
but lately having little sleep,
I lie restless for hours and hours,
longing vainly to wake him up.

The cuckoo lies on his God-given bed;
the gentle breeze always caresses him;
the nocturnal music lulls him throughout,
and his sleep is sound
free from cares and worries

I lie in my concrete house,
fighting against the man-made heat,
and the dreary sound of the hot-wave fan.
The late and heavy supper in stomach,
and all such unnatural ways of life
take away that God's own gift.

Ah, the cuckoo finally calls me out;
let me get up, get out of my cell,
and have a bath in the pool of morning beauty.



25. Vrinda

Vrinda, twelve or thirteen
on the TV yesterday.
Angelic her appearance,
dancing like a peacock
to Hindi film tunes.
Ha! Dancing just on one leg.
The other leg?
Folded under skirt?
Eyes searched for it.
God, only one leg!
Skipping like a kangaroo.
Pricked my heart;
started aching.
Why is destiny so cruel?
She illumines this world;
entertains millions.
Who can console her?
Who will comfort her?
Her life only begun;
has suffered much.
Thousands of miles ahead
to tread with lone leg.
She turned her challenge
to strength and success.
A loud message for the world!

26. What a Birth!

Just returned
from the furnace
after the tarring work.

Burning body
longing cooling haven
but a frozen house.

A thatched hut
cardboard walls
boltless door.

Bed-ridden mother
hungry mouth
beckoning me.

Daughter from school
empty stomach
longing for food.

Rice in the pot
lunch for ma and daughter
stray dogs feasted.

Drunkard husband
will come at night
to resume beats and kicks.

Dawn for doom
Dusk to damn
What a birth!

27. Human Brain

Human brain;
the centre of
pleasures and pains;
that which makes man
distinct from other beings;
a boon or bane?
Birds of the sky;
all beings of the land;
fishes in water;
past never haunts,
nor their future.
No worries;
no dreams;
content always.
If heaven is happiness,
and happiness heaven,
they are in
and we are out.

28. Indian Democracy

Indian democracy:
the largest on the planet;
a wonder to the world.
Parliament elections:
several billion business;
stage of heinous means.
Secularism butchered;
caste and religion
raise their hood;
regionalism and parochialism
devour
nationalism and patriotism.
National parties play
trump cards with communalism;
bow their heads before priests.
The real issues of the country
never discussed among people.
Election campaigns:
fireworks of lies and abuses.
Terrorists try to sabotage,
killing civilians, police, soldiers.
Thus democracy reigns
drinking tears of thousands!
Criminal MPs,
brought from jails
to prove majority on floor;
horse-trade of billions!

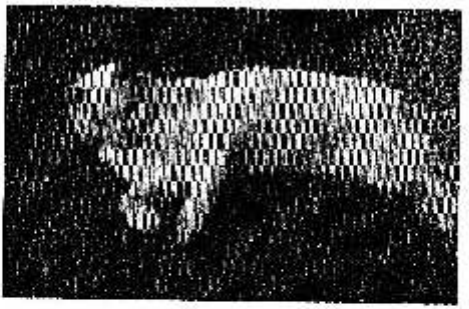
Corrupt governments,
draining the blood of people.
Gratitude to the voters!
Gullible people,
they vote them again and again;
no other options.
Still democracy shall prevail
or tyranny will
sit on the Chair.



29. Ammini's Lament

How to expiate
the merciless sin
committed to my cat?
Ammini's heart-breaking wails,
her unnatural reverberating cry,
piercing through my heart,
and then to my wife.
Ammini can't forget
even after ten days
the loss of her darlings.
Day in and day out
she wanders on all sides
seeking the twins of her triplet.
When troubles increased,
in a weak moment
I had to sell them.
Ammini's incessant cry,
like Gandhari's wails,
echoes my premises.
The pangs of my heart,
a laughingstock to my guests;
Inhumane to animals,
they do believe,
all creations are for men,
since they are born
in God's own image.
Ammini's changed a lot;

no greed for food;
no frolic with her son.
How long will she go on wailing?
Will she curse me as Gandhari did?
Destined like the 'Ancient Mariner'
I'm desperate for the purging amends.



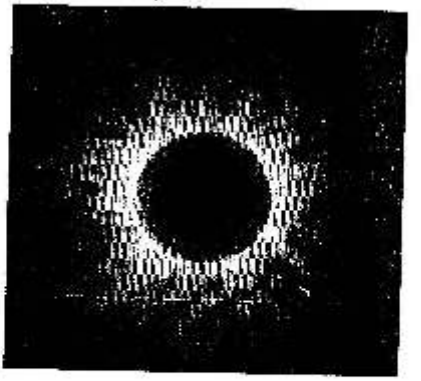
30. Ammini's Demise

My Ammini cat's demise
steals my sleep.
Day in, day out,
her snow-white figure,
her emerald eyes,
black bushy tail,
her gentle demeanour,
her sleep on my lap,
throng my heart,
and hangs me down.
Let me add to Keats':
A thing of beauty
is a joy forever;
and its loss
sorrow forever.
Poisoned to death
Ammini's struggle
for breath and water;
our effort in vain
to keep her alive;
and her final adieu
without even a sound;
wife's moans and wails,
haunt me and
my heart bleeds,
pricked by thorns around.

God, why did You
call her back?
Lived only one year;
gave only happiness.
She was a friend
to my lonely mother;
gave solace to her
when gasping for breath.
How could that fiend
poison this angel?
What harm had it
done to him?
When he was sleeping sound
my darling was
struggling for breath.
Thousands of fiends
inhabit this planet,
turning the earth
to a big slaughter house,
as if man alone has
the right to live here.
God, make them humane
and turn them into angels.

31. Om

Om, the birth-cry of this world;
the very first sound echoing everywhere;
the rhythm of all creations;
from atoms to stars
Om goes on ringing.
Combination of three letters,
representing Vishnu, Shiva, Brahma,
and meaning Brahman.
Father of all mantras;
past and future live in this sound.
Once monopoly of the high caste;
low-caste people were denied
it's listening and muttering;
destined to recite 'Om.'
Worm-like man challenges the Creator;
Om, the holiest mantra of mantras;
key to all problems of the world;
Om is our breath;
a tonic to mind and body.
It's a celestial music
showering manna on the earth;
it gives us peace and happiness;
Om Shanti, Om Shanti, Om Shanti.



32. Solar Eclipse

The moon tried hard
to hide the sun;
but the radiant brilliance
spilled over the moon.
Humiliated and frightened
she slid from his presence.

The sun of knowledge
can never be eclipsed
by the moon of ignorance.

Moons of the world here
seduce suns of virtue.
Corrupt governments devour
suns of innocence.
Fair is foul
and foul is fair.

33. Pleasures and Pains

Pleasures and pains:
two sides of a coin.
We toss it early morning;
majority gets the pains side.
Pleasures come like sprinkles,
while pains fall like a deluge
and continue like monsoon.
Happiness is a mist
while sorrows shower like snow.

34. In the Name of God

Criminal actions done
in the name of God
outnumber
philanthropic services done
in the name of God.
Millions were killed in crusades
in the name of God.
Democracy is devalued
in the name of God.
Nepotism is supported
in the name of God.
Superstitions survive
in the name of God.
Communalism poisons
in the name of God.
Communism is strangled
in the name of God.
Terrorists butcher thousands
in the name of God.
Teens become terrorists
in the name of God.
Sexism prevails
in the name of God.
Higher castes exploit
in the name of God.
Secularism is nullified
in the name of God.

Corruption is promoted
in the name of God.
God is dethroned
in the name of God.
And human gods are crowned
in the name of God.

35. City Versus Village

"Dear, it seems some neighbour is dead."
"Yea, the dirge is from a close house.
Just go and see," my wife said.
The mournful song
came from a rented house.
Though a hundred metres away
we never went there,
nor they visited our house.
The head of the family lay dead
in a flower-covered freezer.
While alive might have dreamed
of an AC bedroom.
He brought it at high interest-rate,
his body shrunken to the bones.
an insult to the dead!
I join the mourning with
the bereaved family,
though none is known to me.
How hard it is—
the city dwellers—
Busy and selfish,
devoid of humanity
Each one lost
in his own island.
A crow, friendly to community;
A dog there is
friendly to other dogs.

How innocent and malice-free
is village life!
where all live
in harmony and love.
They are gullible—
so fooled and cheated
and looted by the townsmen.

36. Cry of My Child

God, can't bear that
heart-rending cry,
like an arrow
piercing through my heart.
She is hungry
and needs feeding;
breasts are swelling with milk.
How will I complete the exam?
Two more hours left;
easy questions;
know all answers;
but can't concentrate;
the pen isn't moving.
Graduate and unemployed;
took my BA five years ago;
applied for many jobs;
wrote test after test.
Husband daily wager;
sole earner of the family;
has to feed seven members;
his aged parents
and his younger sisters.
Oh, my child is still crying;
sister-in-law is helpless.
Should I quit and feed my child?
God, don't you hear my cry?

37. Kaumudi Teacher is No More

Kaumudi Teacher is no more with us;
that light went out on fourth August.
The beacon which guided many women
was destroyed by the wave of Time.
A lone fighter, a role model;
a single woman to fulfil her mission.
Driven by her father's vision,
joined politics in her teens
Gandhi's charisma drew her
attended Gandhi's address at Vadakara;
A meeting to raise fund for Harijans
exhorted all to be generous;
women might donate their ornaments.
Kaumudi, only sixteen, mounted the stage;
gave her golden bangles first;
then gave the chain on her neck;
and finally the jewel studs.
Gandhi, moved and pleased,
concealed his wonder.
Asked if she sought her parents' consent.
Her father there nodded.
Kaumudi pledged to wear no ornament;
she led a humble life;
taught Hindi in Malabar schools;
closely followed Gandhi's footsteps;
taught national language
till her death at ninety-two.

Kaumudi's dazzle dimmed
the dazzle of all other women in jewels and ornaments.
Let's bow our head to this rarest gem.

Vadakara, Malabar are places in the State of Kerala in India.

38. How I Became a Vegetarian

My mind used to taunt me:
"Hey Mister, incongruous
are your words and actions;
what do you write and teach?
The relation between
Man and Nature and God;
human beings and other beings,
all children of God;
Man has no right
to torture any other being.
Hey Mister, have you no shame
to eat the flesh of
innocent animals and fish?"
Born a Christian,
lived a non-veg life;
believed the teachings
that man is the centre of universe;
God made other beings
for his food and assistance.
Millions live in illusions.
Gandhi is my role model;
my eyes are opened at last
and I have become
a pure vegetarian.

39. Michael Jackson, King of Kings

Michael Jackson,
thou art gone;
beckoned back
to feast His senses.
Angels sing and dance
to your lightning steps.
You were the king of kings,
both of music and dance.
Reigned the world
for several decades;
risked your body,
and challenged the White.
Could win million hearts,
staked your health
for the fulfilment of art.
Irreplaceable is the loss—
The chasm widens
in width and depth;
many who try or shall try
to bridge
will feel the folly.

